the function. ‘Where is Rahul?’ was the media chorus outside 10, Janpath. Trying to avoid the forest of cameras, the Congress, it seemed, had no answer. An hour later, the AICC issued a press statement saying that Rahul, after a hectic three-month campaign, had taken a short break and was ‘out of town’. He had reportedly already met the prime minister over the previous weekend and expressed his gratitude in person.

The damage had been done. The Twitter-friendly Omar Abdullah was among the first to react. ‘If you knew he was not attending the dinner and he had explained his absence to the PM earlier, please put out a statement before the news breaks.’ So, where, indeed, was Rahul? As usual, the Congress wouldn’t divulge his whereabouts. Dubai was one guess. ‘Far East’ was another surmise (apparently, in a yoga camp in Myanmar, we were told by one CWC member). It all seemed rather strange. It was bad enough that Rahul was never in town on his birthday while Congress workers lined up to greet him; now, he had chosen to skip a dinner which the Congress party, of which he was vice president, was hosting for their prime minister. It was not just poor form; to the outside world, it smacked of plain and simple bad manners. Sonia, I was later told, was angry at Rahul’s no-show but could do little about it. ‘The fact is, the one person in the Congress she had no control over was her son—he could overrule her,’ a senior Congress MP told me later.

In an election season where so much had gone wrong for the Congress party, this was one final embarrassment they could have done without.

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The 16th of May was like any other excruciatingly hot summer day. Life, though, was easier for me since I was to be in an air-conditioned studio for the 6 a.m. live coverage. Driving to the studio in the early hours of the morning, my mind was transported to the first election I had done on television. The 1996 general elections marked my television debut—then we were doing the elections for Doordarshan. If counting day now was a bit like a T20 match, then it was like a five-day Test match.